

# Unlearning Anti-Black Racism

Recognizing and unlearning anti-Black bias in yourself

4 lenses · tips & action steps — by EvaTalk

## CONTENTS

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1. Before you begin
2. The 4 approaches
3. Psychodynamic lens
4. CBT lens
5. Humanistic lens
6. Systemic lens
7. Tips & advice
8. Your workbook
9. Your 4-week plan

## BEFORE YOU BEGIN

# Recognizing and unlearning anti-Black bias in yourself

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Anti-Black racism saturates our societies, and we've all absorbed it to varying degrees, often unwittingly. Deconstructing it takes honesty and courage.

This guide supports you without sterile guilt, but without minimizing anything. One rule holds the thread: what matters is the impact on the people affected, not your intention.

### **Your intention**

A moment when you realized (or were told) you held an anti-Black bias: \_\_\_\_\_

## The 4 approaches

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This guide works your topic through 4 complementary psychology lenses. Read, do the exercises, fill the workbook — at your own pace.

**Psychodynamic** — understand the root.

**CBT** — ease the negative thoughts.

**Humanistic** — reconcile with yourself.

**Systemic** — act on your environment.

## Where these biases come from

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No one is born anti-Black: these biases are learned — through media, representations, history, the silence of those around us, fear of ‘the other’. What’s learned can be unlearned.

Understanding the origin is never an excuse: it’s what gives you leverage to change.

### *Example*

*Rethinking the images and ‘jokes’ of his childhood, Thomas saw where he’d learned to link the worst with skin color. Seeing it helped him undo it.*

### **Where I learned it**

What messages (media, family, peers) fed your negative associations about Black people?

### **Learned, so unlearnable**

Write: ‘These biases come from outside — and it’s my responsibility to undo them.’

→ *These biases are learned — so I can, and must, unlearn them.*

## Seeing what you'd rather not see

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Automatic associations, diffuse fear, exoticization, 'you're not like the others', surprise at a Black person's success: these are biases, even without 'bad intent'.

Spotting them means stopping the self-justification and looking at the impact of your actions.

### *Example*

*Sarah noticed she clutched her bag in the elevator depending on who entered. Rather than defend herself, she noted the reflex — and began to question it.*

### **My automatics**

Note 2 automatic reactions/thoughts you had that reflect an anti-Black bias.

### **Impact, not intent**

For one of them: what impact could it have had, regardless of your intention?

*→ I look my biases in the face — without justifying myself.*

## Aligning your actions with your values

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Most people say they value equality. Deconstruction is closing the gap between those values and your actual reflexes — by truly listening to Black people, without centering yourself.

Empathy is cultivated: listen, believe, decenter.

### *Example*

*Instead of saying 'but I'm not racist', Karim started listening to what Black colleagues described — and finally heard.*

### **My values/actions gap**

What value do you claim? Where do your reflexes not yet honor it?

### **Listen, decenter**

Name a source (book, Black creator) you'll listen to — without demanding to be taught.

→ *I close the gap between my values and my reflexes — by listening.*

## From intentions to action

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Concretely: educate yourself (don't make Black people do this work), interrupt anti-Black racism around you, repair when you cause harm, and welcome feedback without fragility or defensiveness.

Deconstruction is proven in action, not declarations — and it's lifelong work.

### *Example*

*When a relative made a racist 'joke', Léa, instead of laughing out of awkwardness, calmly said it wasn't funny to her. The bit stopped.*

### **My action**

One concrete way to act this week (interrupt, support, educate yourself, repair): \_\_\_\_\_

### **Welcoming feedback**

Write: 'If I'm told a behavior was racist, I listen instead of defending myself.'

→ *I prove deconstruction in action — it's ongoing work.*

## Practical tips & advice

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### Tips & advice

- Biases are learned — so they can be unlearned; but it's your responsibility.
- What matters is impact, not your intention.
- Welcome discomfort without centering it: your awkwardness is nothing next to lived racism.
- Educate yourself (books, Black creators) — don't demand that Black people explain it to you.
- When told a behavior was racist, listen instead of defending yourself.
- Take action (interrupt, repair, support); it's lifelong work, not a box to tick.



## To fill in

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### My spotted biases

| The reflex / thought | Its possible impact |
|----------------------|---------------------|
|                      |                     |
|                      |                     |
|                      |                     |
|                      |                     |
|                      |                     |

### My actions

| Concrete action | When |
|-----------------|------|
|                 |      |
|                 |      |
|                 |      |
|                 |      |

## PLAN

# Your 4-week plan

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**Week 1** — Understand where I learned these biases.

**Week 2** — Spot my automatics (without justifying).

**Week 3** — Listen / educate myself, decentering.

**Week 4** — Act: interrupt, repair, support.

### Your plan in 3 lines

- The bias I'm working on:
- The source I educate myself with:
- My first concrete action:

TO CLOSE

## **Anti-Black racism is learned — unlearning it is your responsibility, and it's possible.**

*Anti-Black racism is learned — unlearning it is your responsibility.*

*This guide is a reflection and psychoeducation tool for deconstructing your own biases — not therapy. Deconstruction is ongoing work: discomfort is part of the path, but the goal remains real impact on the people affected, not your comfort. ©*

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